

Module 11: Go for Certification or Not?

Once most of the management system is implemented and functioning, an important question arises: Should the organization seek certification? Implementing a management system already provides numerous benefits, and certification is not mandatory. However, as a project manager, you and your project sponsor should discuss this decision with the management team by weighing the benefits and drawbacks of certification.

Benefits of Certification

1. Marketing Tool
 - a. Certification can attract new clients, especially in competitive industries where competitors may already be certified.
2. Improved Compliance
 - b. Certification often aligns with regulatory standards, making compliance more manageable and structured.
3. Cost Reduction
 - c. Certified organizations may face fewer external audits from clients, reducing associated costs.
4. Enhanced Internal Motivation
 - d. Certification deadlines can act as a powerful motivator, ensuring timely completion and compliance within the organization.
5. Ongoing Discipline
 - e. Annual audits required for maintaining certification help sustain discipline and prevent lapses in procedure adherence.
6. Benchmarking with Industry Standards
 - f. Certification allows the organization to benchmark against industry leaders, with valuable input from experienced auditors.

Drawbacks of Certification

1. Additional Costs
 - g. Certification involves initial and ongoing expenses, which may be unnecessary if clients don't require certification.

Decision-Making Considerations

If the management team decides to proceed with certification, consider the following:

- h. Readiness for Certification Requirements
- i. Ensure a full internal audit cycle and management review are complete.
- j. Timing for Certification Audit
- k. Select a date that allows ample preparation.
- l. Evidence Collection
- m. Gather historical data as evidence for the certification audit.
- n. Choosing a Certification Body
- o. Decide on criteria to select a reputable certification body.

Choosing a Certification Body

Selecting a certification body involves more than just evaluating costs. Consider these essential criteria to make an informed decision:

Key Criteria for Selection

1. Reputation
 - a. Ensure the certification body has a strong reputation for credible assessments, especially if certification is for marketing purposes.
2. Accreditation
 - b. Confirm the body is accredited, meaning it has the proper authority to issue recognized certificates.
3. Specialization
 - c. Choose a body experienced in your industry; for example, banks should select a body familiar with financial services.
4. Experience
 - d. Opt for an auditor with substantial experience for valuable insights during the audit.
5. Language Compatibility
 - a. Prefer a body with auditors who speak your language to enhance communication and ensure efficient document review.

Requesting Quotations

After shortlisting two or three certification bodies that meet your criteria, request quotes from each. Certification bodies typically require information on:

- b. Organization Size (number of employees)
- c. Industry Code (e.g., NACE in the EU)
- d. Operational Scope (e.g., number of sites, shifts, and temporary sites if applicable)

Once you've evaluated all criteria, select the certification body that best aligns with your organization's needs and proceed with the application.

Certification Process

The certification process for a management system includes several key stages, each designed to assess and confirm compliance with standards.

Key Stages of the Certification Process

1. Offer and Contract Phase
 - a. Finalize a contract with the chosen certification body.
2. Optional Pre-Audit
 - b. An organization can request a pre-audit for early feedback on conformity with standards before the formal audit begins.
3. Certification Audit
 - c. The audit is conducted in two main stages:
 - d. Stage 1 Audit: Evaluates management documentation against relevant standards.
 - e. Stage 2 Audit: Conducts a thorough on-site audit (or partially remote if applicable) to verify compliance and issues the certification upon successful completion.
4. Annual Surveillance Audits
 - a. These audits help maintain certification by ensuring ongoing compliance.
5. Recertification Audit (Every 3 Years)
 - a. A comprehensive audit to renew the certification, typically conducted every three years.

This streamlined certification process ensures that the organization's management system remains in alignment with the standards and undergoes regular review.

Stage 1 and Stage 2 Audits

The certification process includes two main audit stages to ensure compliance with the management system standards.

Stage 1 Audit

1. Documentation Review
 - b. The auditor reviews the management system documentation against standard requirements and verifies the clarity of the SCOPA certification.
2. Internal Audits and Management Review
 - c. Ensures that internal audits and management reviews are planned and conducted.

3. Readiness for Stage 2 Audit
 - d. Confirms the management system's implementation level; any non-conformities must be corrected before proceeding.
4. Audit Report
 - e. A report detailing findings is issued; if readiness is lacking, the Stage 2 audit may be postponed or cancelled.

Stage 2 Audit

1. Audit Plan and Timing
 - f. Typically occurs weeks to six months after Stage 1 to allow time for corrective actions.
2. Implementation Verification
 - g. Focuses on process and procedure implementation, with auditor interviews, site visits, and audit trail analysis.
3. Final Meeting
 - a. The lead auditor reviews audit results with involved employees and management, detailing both positive findings and issues.
4. Audit Findings
 - a. Findings include:
 - b. Non-Conformities
 - c. Major: Indicate significant system issues; must be corrected before certification.
 - d. Minor: Allow certification, but require follow-up at the next surveillance audit.
 - e. Observations
 - f. Suggestions for improvement based on auditor experience.

Certification Validity and Maintenance

1. Certificate Validity
 - a. Valid for three years with annual surveillance audits to verify system maintenance.
2. Recertification Audit
 - a. Conducted before the certificate expires to review improvements and address any trends in non-conformities.

This streamlined process ensures that the organization consistently maintains and improves its management system over time.

Preparing for the Certification Audit

Preparing thoroughly for the certification audit helps ensure that audit results align with expectations and the management system meets standards.

Preparation Steps

1. Address Deviations Early
 - b. Review any deviations and take corrective actions before the certification audit begins.
2. Internal Audit and Management Review
 - c. Internal auditors and top management should verify that the management system meets requirements through a detailed management review.
3. Ensure Resource Allocation
 - d. Confirm that necessary resources are available to support the management system's effectiveness.
4. Root Cause Analysis and Creative Actions
 - e. Investigate root causes for any issues found in internal audits or management reviews and implement creative actions to resolve them.
5. Proactive Problem-Solving
 - f. Certification auditors will appreciate if known issues have already been identified, investigated, and addressed through your system, showing effective internal control.

This structured approach demonstrates the organization's commitment to continual improvement and readiness for the certification audit.

Logistics of the Certification Audit

Proper logistical preparation helps ensure a smooth and effective certification audit process.

Key Logistics for the Certification Audit

1. Audit Scheduling and Duration
 - g. Certification Body proposes audit dates and calculates duration based on organization size, sites, and standards.
 - h. Once dates are set, confirm readiness with all involved.
2. Special Requirements for Auditors
 - a. Notify the Certification Body of any specific requirements, such as personal protective equipment or security clearances.

3. Document Requests
 - b. Certification Auditors may request documents like:
 - c. Organizational charts and site layouts
 - d. Management system policies, objectives, procedures
 - e. Relevant standards, legislation, and compliance records
 - f. Internal audits, management reviews, and corrective action records
4. Audit Agenda
 - a. Lead Auditor provides a proposed agenda, including:
 - b. Audit areas, locations, and planned interviews
 - c. Review and discuss any necessary changes with the auditor for a mutually agreeable schedule.
5. Audit Team Support
 - a. Assign team members to accompany each auditor if multiple auditors are involved.

This preparation ensures clarity, minimizes disruptions, and facilitates a comprehensive audit.

Preparing Your People for the Certification Audit

Preparing employees and the site for the certification audit helps ensure confidence, clarity, and compliance.

Employee Preparation

1. Explain the Certification
 - a. Discuss what certification means, its importance, and how employees can contribute.
2. Key Responsibilities
 - b. Encourage employees to:
 - c. Familiarize themselves with company policies.
 - d. Review relevant documents and records.
 - e. Keep work areas clean and organized.
 - f. Be prepared to answer auditor questions accurately without guessing; it's acceptable to check information if unsure.
3. Reduce Anxiety
 - a. Reassure employees that auditors focus on verifying compliance, not seeking errors, and that their goal is to confirm the system is followed as planned.
4. Audit Question Awareness

- b. Share examples of what auditors might ask so employees feel more confident and prepared.

Site Preparation

1. Organize and Clean Up
 - c. Ensure all areas are tidy and free of clutter to minimize risks of non-conformities.
2. Document and Instrument Checks
 - d. Confirm documents are controlled, accessible, and up-to-date.
 - e. Verify measuring instruments are calibrated, and all parts/supplies are clearly identified.

This preparation helps create a smooth, effective audit process, demonstrating the organization's commitment to standards.

What to Expect from Certification Auditors

Certification auditors focus on verifying compliance with standards and confirming that the management system is effective and achieving intended outcomes.

Expectations from Certification Auditors

1. Compliance Check
 - a. Auditors ensure activities align with both relevant standards and internal documentation.
2. Auditor Permissions
 - b. Allowed to interview any employee within the certification scope, review any document, and inspect any area of the premises.
3. Role Limitations
 - c. Auditors are not consultants; they can't provide specific solutions to issues but may offer general guidance on addressing non-conformities.

Avoiding Auditor Annoyance

1. Cooperation

- d. Be honest, responsive, and cooperative—don't waste time, avoid questions, or mislead.

Challenging Auditor Findings

1. Standards-Based Findings Only
 - e. Auditors can only raise non-conformities if there's a requirement in the standard or internal documentation and clear evidence of non-compliance.
2. Disputable Situations
 - f. If an auditor's request isn't standards-based or there's no proof of non-compliance, you have grounds to respectfully challenge it.

This guidance helps in building a productive and positive audit experience, with clear expectations for compliance and interaction.

Post-Certification Audit Process

After the certification audit, the audit team prepares a report detailing their findings, including non-conformities and opportunities for improvement.

Audit Report and Final Meeting

1. Audit Report Contents
 - g. Findings of the audit.
 - h. Types of non-conformities identified (major or minor).
 - i. Observations for potential improvements.
2. Final Meeting
 - a. Audit team presents results and findings.
 - b. Communicates recommendation for certification.

Understanding Non-Conformities

1. Non-Conformity Impact
 - a. The number of non-conformities reflects compliance: more non-conformities indicate lower compliance.
2. Major Non-Conformities
 - b. Definition: Significant failures in compliance that prevent certification.

- c. Characteristics:
 - d. Complete failure to meet a requirement (e.g., no management reviews).
 - e. Critical process breakdowns (e.g., irregular backups).
 - f. Multiple related minor non-conformities indicating systemic issues (e.g., HR-related deficiencies).
- 3. Minor Non-Conformities
 - a. Definition: Issues that do not significantly impact compliance.
 - b. Example: Backup performed daily except for one day in a month.

Corrective Actions and Follow-Up

- 1. Deadline for Resolution
 - a. Non-conformities must be addressed within 30 to 90 days, as stated in the audit report.
- 2. Corrective Actions
 - b. Ensure actions resolve the root cause of non-conformities.
 - c. Notify the audit team and provide evidence of corrective actions taken.
- 3. Verification of Actions
 - a. For major non-conformities, an additional audit may be required.
 - b. Minor non-conformities can lead to certification if corrective actions are accepted.

Certification Validity and Maintenance

- 1. Certification Issuance
 - a. Successful resolution of non-conformities leads to certification issuance.
- 2. Validity Period
 - b. Certificates are valid for three years, subject to annual surveillance audits.
- 3. Suspension Risk
 - c. Certification can be suspended if major non-conformities are identified during surveillance audits.

This summary provides a clear outline of the post-audit process, expectations, and necessary actions to maintain certification.